

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Government and Public Administration English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For public administrators, agency program managers, policy analysts, procurement staff, constituent-service teams, grants managers, and interagency coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Applying a program rule

02 Public meeting preparation

03 Procurement evaluation

04 Grant reporting discrepancy

05 Interagency referral

06 Constituent complaint

07 Records request

08 Budget justification

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Applying a program rule

An agency team interprets an eligibility question.

Roles: Program officer / Policy adviser

Program officer: This application falls between two examples in our guidance. Can we reject it using the closest one?

Policy adviser: Check the governing rule and the approved interpretation process. An example may not cover this case.

Program officer: What should I tell the applicant while we review it?

Policy adviser: Explain what information is missing and that a decision is pending, without implying an outcome.

Program officer: I'll document the facts and request policy clarification.

Policy adviser: We'll record the interpretation so comparable cases can be handled consistently.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "This application falls between two examples in our guidance. Can we reject it using the closest one?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Public meeting preparation

Staff plan a meeting on a proposed service change.

Roles: Public engagement officer / Program manager

Public engagement officer: Residents want to know whether the decision has already been made.

Program manager: The proposal is under review. We need to explain which parts remain open to input.

Public engagement officer: I'll include that in the opening and publish the consultation questions.

Program manager: Also explain how comments will be recorded and considered.

Public engagement officer: We'll provide accessible ways to participate and avoid treating attendance as agreement.

Program manager: I'll prepare a factual explanation of the options, constraints, and next decision stage.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Residents want to know whether the decision has already been made." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Procurement evaluation

A procurement team notices a proposed change in scoring.

Roles: Procurement officer / Evaluation chair

Procurement officer: One evaluator wants to increase the weight for presentation quality after seeing the bids.

Evaluation chair: We need to follow the published evaluation criteria and applicable procurement process.

Procurement officer: I'll document the concern and seek the required procedural advice.

Evaluation chair: Keep individual scoring records intact and manage conflicts of interest through the approved route.

Procurement officer: Should we pause consolidation until the issue is resolved?

Evaluation chair: Yes, coordinate that through procurement and record the decision before the panel proceeds.

Notice the professional language

evaluation criteria - The stated standards used to compare or assess options or performance.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Grant reporting discrepancy

An agency reconciles a grantee's report.

Roles: Grants manager / Program analyst

Grants manager: The financial report includes travel costs outside the stated reporting period.

Program analyst: Could those be late payments for activities in the eligible period?

Grants manager: Possibly. We need the dates, supporting records, and the award's reporting rules.

Program analyst: Ask for clarification before labeling the costs ineligible.

Grants manager: I'll identify the specific entries and the required explanation.

Program analyst: I'll compare the response with the program records and route any unresolved compliance issue for review.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Could those be late payments for activities in the eligible period?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Interagency referral

Two agencies clarify a case referral.

Roles: Agency coordinator / Partner-agency liaison

Agency coordinator: We sent the referral last week, but we haven't received acknowledgment.

Partner-agency liaison: Our intake system has it, though the responsible team hasn't accepted it yet.

Agency coordinator: Who can confirm ownership and the next contact with the resident?

Partner-agency liaison: I'll follow up with intake and confirm the appropriate transfer under our agreement.

Agency coordinator: We'll retain the current status rather than mark the case completed.

Partner-agency liaison: I'll send an acknowledgment with the accepted responsibilities and any information still required.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Who can confirm ownership and the next contact with the resident?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Constituent complaint

Staff respond to an unresolved service complaint.

Roles: Constituent services officer / Department supervisor

Constituent services officer: The resident has called three times about an unanswered permit inquiry.

Department supervisor: Let's check the actual application status before promising a resolution date.

Constituent services officer: The file shows an information request, but it wasn't sent to the current address.

Department supervisor: Correct that through the records process and explain the communication error plainly.

Constituent services officer: I'll confirm the contact details and give a time for the next update.

Department supervisor: I'll assign a case owner and verify that the missing request is delivered appropriately.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The resident has called three times about an unanswered permit inquiry." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Records request

An officer receives a broad public-records request.

Roles: Records officer / Department manager

Records officer: The request covers emails about the project. Should staff delete duplicates before collecting them?

Department manager: Follow the records-preservation and review process. Don't alter the source records to simplify the response.

Records officer: I'll clarify the search scope and identify likely custodians.

Department manager: Route questions about exemptions and disclosure to the authorized reviewers.

Records officer: I'll record search methods and any locations we still need to check.

Department manager: Keep the requester informed through the applicable process without promising disclosure before review.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The request covers emails about the project. Should staff delete duplicates before collecting them?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Budget justification

A manager prepares a budget request.

Roles: Program manager / Budget analyst

Program manager: We want ten percent more funding because demand rose. Is the case strong enough?

Budget analyst: Show demand, service capacity, outcomes, and the cost of the proposed response on a consistent basis.

Program manager: Our applications increased, but completed cases didn't. The queue grew instead.

Budget analyst: Then explain that bottleneck and compare options, including recurring costs.

Program manager: I'll separate the additional staffing request from the one-time system expense.

Budget analyst: Include measurable objectives so the decision group can assess the proposal and later review its results.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We want ten percent more funding because demand rose. Is the case strong enough?"
What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Policy Implementation and Program Rules

SHARED CASE

A resident mistakes draft eligibility guidance for a final rule. The office has published current guidance and a separate proposal.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The proposal is under review; the current published guidance remains the reference for today's process. Let me show you the distinction and where official updates will appear.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

SHARED CASE

At a public meeting, two speakers use most of the time and several people have not been heard. The meeting has an announced participation process.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Let's return to the announced speaking process so more people can contribute. I'll summarize the points raised and invite the next speaker, while keeping the record clear about what remains unresolved.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Procurement and Vendor Selection

SHARED CASE

A procurement evaluation note uses "best value" without linking the judgment to published evaluation criteria.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which stated criteria support that assessment? Please connect the evidence to those criteria so the review explains the basis for the judgment rather than relying on a general label.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

SHARED CASE

A grant report contains a total expenditure figure but lacks the requested supporting categories.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you provide the category breakdown and supporting references required for this report? If an item is unresolved, please identify it so the grants team can explain the next step.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Interagency Coordination

SHARED CASE

Two agencies are coordinating a service request. Each assumes the other will contact the resident.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we confirm which agency will make the next contact and by when? I'll record that responsibility and the permitted information-sharing route so the resident receives a coordinated response.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Constituent Services and Escalation

SHARED CASE

A resident has been redirected between offices without an explanation of who can address the issue.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'm sorry you have been redirected without a clear explanation. Let me identify the office with the relevant authority and confirm the next contact rather than send you on without that information.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Transparency, Records, and Ethics

SHARED CASE

A records request involves material that may require review for an exemption. An initial note says all material will automatically be released.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The request needs review under the applicable records process. I'll avoid promising a release decision before that review and explain how the office will communicate the outcome.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

SHARED CASE

A budget proposal lists activities delivered but does not show the intended public outcomes.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The activity count tells us what was delivered. We also need to explain the intended outcome and how it will be assessed. I'll connect the spending request to that public-purpose question.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.